

CUTTING DOWN TRANSIT TIME

● Coal transit from eastern, northern and central coalfields to power plants in North reduced by 24 hours

● In the routes where transit time has been cut the most, the reduction is over 30 hours

	Reserve stock days	Running time of IR before DFC (hours)	Running time of DFC route (hours)	Saved transit time (hours)
GTTPP Siding Lehra	12	71.1	38.1	33
GVK Power Goindwal Sahib	4	74.18	42.1	32.08
RTP Siding Ropar	21	67.3	37.1	30.2
Nabha Power	13	66.06	35.54	30.12
Suratgarh Thermal Power	7	72.1	42.23	29.47

SOURCE DFCCIL

loading across Indian Railways saw a 5% YoY increase to 1,591 million tonnes (MT) in FY24, the highest ever.

One place where the shift is becoming evident is in the Dadri DFC section in Uttar Pradesh, which connects the nearby multimodal logistics hub spread across 823 acres being built at a cost of over ₹7,000 crore and allows double stacking of containers. It is also at the intersection of the eastern and western DFCs.

About 60-70% of containerised traffic moves between western and northern India, and it is primarily EXIM traffic shipped through major ports like Mundra, Pipavav, and JNPT.

The country's biggest hauler, Container Corporation of India (Concor), feels that once the DFC connects to JNPT by the end of FY25, there will be a significant shift of cargo from road to rail.

"The rail coefficient (percentage of freight carried by rail over the total availability) will increase from 18% to around 25-30% at JNPT. The JNPT coming on the DFC will be very exciting for us because we are building new terminals," Concor CMD Sanjay Swarup said during an investor call.

The Mundra and Pipavav ports have already started reaping the benefits of the DFC connection, with an increase in volumes and a reduction in wagon turn-around times.

Subrata Tripathy, CEO of Ports Business at Adani Ports and SEZ Ltd, says the double-stack ratio at Mundra Port has seen a significant jump of around 10%.

"The double-stack ratio has significantly grown from 54% last year to about 63%, and that's only accruing out of the continuous DFC that has since been connected, both on the main line as well as the subsidiary feeder route (Mundra Port). This gives us an advantage of double stacking as well as the relative distance advantage over the main competitors, Pipavav and JNPT," Tripathy said during an investor call in February. Both Adani Ports and Concor did not respond to queries sent by BT.

Sanjiv Garg, former MD of Pipavav Railway Corporation Ltd, says the port has also seen faster container movement post-DFC connectivity. "Pipavav port

has electric line connectivity with DFC, while Mundra still has single-line diesel connectivity," he says.

According to logistics players, the DFC has turned out to be great, especially for exporters of retail and lifestyle goods from north India and for importers of goods such as electronics, for whom speed to market is extremely important.

Vikash Agarwal, MD of logistics firm Maersk South Asia, says transit time and reliability are the key differentiators, and the DFC has been a great boon for trade as it offers both speed and reliability.

"We have seen that transit times from the hinterland near the NCR to the ports on the western coast have reduced from 72 hours to 36 hours," Agarwal tells BT. "Using rail as a mode of transport also helps reduce the carbon footprint, which has become a significantly important aspect for many organisations," he adds.

TO, OPTIMISE THE USE of DFCs, the Railways has been looking to diversify its freight basket with non-conventional traffic.

The prime example is Amul using the ToT service, through which it loads milk trucks on rakes at Palanpur in Gujarat that are unloaded 659 km away at Rewari in Haryana. The RoRo (roll-on, roll-off) service